

Kill Signal Decision Card — CODE / PEOPLE Triage

Use this card when assessing whether a brownfield project is safe for AI-assisted work. The diagnostic question: **“Is what’s missing an artifact, or human knowledge?”**

Step 1: List the signals you see

#	Signal	Description
1	No Tests	Coverage under 30%
2	No Documentation	Tribal knowledge only
3	Tight Coupling	One change affects >5 modules
4	Complex Business Rules	Scattered, undocumented
5	Regulatory / Compliance	PCI-DSS / AML / GDPR constraints not encoded
6	Team Can’t Evaluate Output	No senior who can verify AI output
7	Model-Context Fit	Codebase in language / DSL agent hasn’t seen
8	Velocity-of-Change	Framework or core dependency mid-migration

Step 2: Tag each signal — CODE or PEOPLE

- **CODE signals** (what’s missing is an artifact AI can produce): 1, 3, 4, 5, 7, 8
- **PEOPLE signals** (what’s missing is human knowledge or evaluation skill): 2, 6

Step 3: For each tagged signal, name the next move

Signal	Category	Next move
1 No Tests	CODE	AI generates characterization tests on existing behavior first
2 No Documentation	PEOPLE	Conversation with the senior; document what they say; THEN AI pre-work
3 Tight Coupling	CODE	AI maps dependency graph + extracts seam interfaces
4 Complex Rules	CODE	AI extracts rules into golden tests + rule registry
5 Regulatory	CODE	AI writes lint rules + compliance checks (no-PII-log, PCI-DSS whitelist) as hooks
6 Can't Evaluate	PEOPLE	Senior mentorship + paired review until evaluation skill grows
7 Model-Context	CODE	AI generates domain README + example library + DSL grammar notes
8 Velocity-of-Change	CODE	AI writes migration tests + version-freeze checks

Step 4: Count by category and read the traffic light

Signals	Color	Action
0-1	GREEN	AI-led. Full agentic workflow. Go.
2-3	YELLOW	AI-assisted. Count by category. CODE-heavy: AI pre-work plan. PEOPLE-heavy: hiring or mentorship plan.
4+	RED	Invest in codebase readiness BEFORE using AI.

Honest framing

A workshop or vendor that promises AI for everything loses your trust on Signal 6 (junior who can't evaluate). PEOPLE signals don't have AI substitutes – they have human investments. The PEOPLE category is the minority of the signal set, but it gates the rest – if your team can't evaluate AI output, no CODE-side artifact closes the gap.

Source

ITSS Workshop, 2026-05-28, Theme 3 (Brownfield Mastery). The CODE / PEOPLE split is the diagnostic taught in Theme 3 and revisited in the 90-day rollout playbook.